

The Spectrum of an Operator

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Outline

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

1 Introduction

- Revision

Outline

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

1 Introduction

- Revision

2 Spectrum

- Definition of Spectrum
- Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum
- Properties and Theorems

Outline

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

1 Introduction

- Revision

2 Spectrum

- Definition of Spectrum
- Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum
- Properties and Theorems

3 Examples of Spectra of Operators

- The Shift Operator

Outline

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

1 Introduction

- Revision

2 Spectrum

- Definition of Spectrum
- Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum
- Properties and Theorems

3 Examples of Spectra of Operators

- The Shift Operator

Revision

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Definition

Let T be a linear operator, $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ is called an eigenvalue of T , if there exists $x \in H$ with $x \neq 0$ such that

$$Tx = \lambda x$$

Example

Consider

$$T : \mathbb{R}^2 \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$$

$$x \longmapsto \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} x$$

$1 \in \mathbb{C}$ is an eigenvalue of T , since there is $(1, 0) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ such that

$$T \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} = 1 \cdot \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

Revision

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of Spectrum

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

Properties and Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Theorem

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a Hilbert space and $T : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ then T is invertible $\iff \ker T^ = \{0\}$ and $\exists \alpha > 0$ such that $\|T(x)\| \geq \alpha \|x\| \quad \forall x \in \mathcal{H}$.*

Revision

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of Spectrum

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

Properties and Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

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Corollary

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a Hilbert space and $T : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ then T is invertible $\iff \exists \beta > 0$ such that $\|T^(x)\| \geq \beta \|x\|$ and $\exists \alpha > 0$ such that $\|T(x)\| \geq \alpha \|x\| \quad \forall x \in \mathcal{H}$.*

Revision

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of Spectrum

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

Properties and Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Proof.

If T is invertible, then so is T^* . So, by Theorem 1, $\exists \beta > 0$ such that $\|T^*(x)\| \geq \beta \|x\|$ and $\exists \alpha > 0$ such that $\|T(x)\| \geq \alpha \|x\|$ for all $x \in H$. Conversely, if $\exists \beta > 0$ such that $\|T^*(x)\| \geq \beta \|x\|$, then if $T^*u = 0$ for some $u \in H$, then

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &= \|T^*u\| \geq \beta \|u\| \\ &\implies u = 0 \end{aligned}$$

So, $\ker T^* = \{0\}$. By Theorem 1, T is invertible. □

Outline

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

1 Introduction

- Revision

2 Spectrum

- Definition of Spectrum
- Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum
- Properties and Theorems

3 Examples of Spectra of Operators

- The Shift Operator

Definition of Spectrum

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Definition

Let T be a linear operator. The resolvent set of T , denoted by $\rho(T)$, is $\rho(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : T - \lambda I \text{ is invertible}\}$. The spectrum of T , denoted by $\sigma(T)$ is $\sigma(T) = \mathbb{C} \setminus \rho(T)$, or equivalently, $\sigma(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : T - \lambda I \text{ is not invertible}\}$

Definition of Spectrum

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Remark

Notice that, if $T \in B(\mathcal{H})$, by Theorem 1, we can rewrite the resolvent set of T as

$$\rho(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : \ker(T - \lambda I)^* = \{0\} \\ \text{and } \|(T - \lambda I)x\| \geq \alpha \|x\| \text{ for some } \alpha > 0\}$$

Alternatively, we can rewrite the resolvent set of T as

$$\rho(T) = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : \|(T - \lambda I)^*x\| \geq \beta \|x\| \\ \text{and } \|(T - \lambda I)x\| \geq \alpha \|x\| \text{ for some } \beta, \alpha > 0\}$$

by Corollary 1

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Theorem

If λ is an eigenvalue of T , then $\lambda \in \sigma(T)$

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Proof.

Suppose that $\lambda \notin \sigma(T)$, then $T - \lambda I$ is invertible. So, we have $(T - \lambda I)u = 0 \implies u = (T - \lambda I)^{-1}(T - \lambda I)u = (T - \lambda I)^{-1}(0) = 0$. So, if there is $u \in \mathcal{H}$ such that $Tu = \lambda u$, then $u = 0$. So, λ is not an eigenvalue of T . $\square$

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Theorem

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a finite dimensional Hilbert space, and let $T : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ be linear. If $\lambda \in \sigma(T)$, then λ is an eigenvalue of T .

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Remark

For finite dimensional Hilbert space, the spectrum of T consist only the eigenvalues of T . However, in infinite dimensional Hilbert space, we may have no eigenvalues. For instance, consider the shift operator. Here, it has no eigenvalues, since if we consider $(T - \lambda I)x = 0$, we see that

$$\begin{aligned}(-\lambda x_1, x_1 - \lambda x_2, x_2 - \lambda x_3, \dots) &= (0, 0, 0, \dots) \\ \implies x &= (0, 0, 0, \dots)\end{aligned}$$

So, T does not have an eigenvalue. However, we showed that T is not invertible. So, $T - 0I$ is not invertible and $0 \in \sigma(T)$. So, the spectrum of an operator does not only consist of eigenvalues.

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Proof.

Suppose that λ is not an eigenvalue of T , then there is nonzero $u \in \mathcal{H}$ such that $Tu = \lambda u$. So, there is no nonzero $u \in \mathcal{H}$ such that $(T - \lambda I)u = 0$. So, $\ker(T - \lambda I) = \{0\}$. By rank-nullity theorem, we have

$$\begin{aligned}\dim \mathcal{H} &= \dim \ker(T - \lambda I) + \dim \operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I) \\ &= 0 + \dim \operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I) \\ &= \dim \operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I)\end{aligned}$$

So, $\operatorname{Im}(T - \lambda I) = \mathcal{H}$. This means that $(T - \lambda I)$ is surjective, and therefore, invertible. So, $\lambda \in \rho(T)$, and therefore, $\lambda \notin \sigma(T)$. □

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Proposition

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a Hilbert space. Let $T : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ be linear operator. The following properties hold:

- ① $\sigma(I) = \{1\}$
- ② $\sigma(T^*) = \{\bar{\lambda} : \lambda \in \sigma(T)\}$
- ③ If T is invertible, then $\sigma(T^{-1}) = \{\mu^{-1} : \mu \in \sigma(T)\}$
- ④ If T is self-adjoint, then $\sigma(T) \subseteq \mathbb{R}$.
- ⑤ If $U : \mathcal{H} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ is invertible, then $\sigma(UTU^{-1}) = \sigma(T)$

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Example

Quantum Physics We have seen that for an observable t , we associate a self-adjoint operator T . **The eigenvalues of the operator T represent the possible values of that observable t .**

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Example

Quantum Physics We have seen that for an observable t , we associate a self-adjoint operator T . **The eigenvalues of the operator T represent the possible values of that observable t .** For example, if we want to find the possible values of the energy, we need to find the eigenvalues of H . In other words, we solve

$$H\psi = E\psi = \left(-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2} + V(x) \right) \psi.$$

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Example

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$$H\psi = E\psi = \left(-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2} + V(x) \right) \psi.$$

*This is the famous **Schrödinger** equation.*

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Lemma

If $\mathcal{H}$ is a complex Hilbert space and $U \in B(\mathcal{H})$ is unitary then

$$\sigma(U) \subseteq \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| = 1\}$$

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Theorem

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a complex Hilbert space and let $T \in B(\mathcal{H})$. If $|\lambda| > \|T\|$ then $\lambda \notin \sigma(T)$.

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Corollary

If $T \in B(\mathcal{H})$, then $\sigma(T)$ is bounded.

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Proof.

If $\lambda \in \sigma(T)$, then, by the contrapositive of Theorem 4, $|\lambda| \leq \|T\|$. So, $\lambda \in \overline{B(0, \|T\|)}$. Hence, $\sigma(T) \subseteq \overline{B(0, \|T\|)}$, i.e. $\sigma(T)$ is bounded. □

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Theorem

If $T \in B(\mathcal{H})$, then $\sigma(T) \subseteq \mathbb{C}$ is a closed set.

Properties and Theorems

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Corollary

If $T \in B(\mathcal{H})$, then $\sigma(T)$ is compact in $\mathbb{C}$

Outline

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

1 Introduction

- Revision

2 Spectrum

- Definition of Spectrum
- Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum
- Properties and Theorems

3 Examples of Spectra of Operators

- The Shift Operator

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

We would like to find the spectrum of the unilateral shift, $T : \ell^2 \rightarrow \ell^2$, defined by

$$T(x_1, x_2, \dots) = (0, x_1, x_2, \dots)$$

Since T has been shown to have no eigenvalue, we will consider the eigenvalues of T^* instead and use the properties of the spectrum to have a lower bound for the spectrum.

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of Spectrum

Relationship between Eigenvalue and Spectrum

Properties and Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Suppose that $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $|\lambda| < 1$, then consider the sequence

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Suppose that $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $|\lambda| < 1$, then consider the sequence

$$x = (1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots)$$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Suppose that $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $|\lambda| < 1$, then consider the sequence

$$x = (1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots)$$

Claim: $x \in \ell^2$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Suppose that $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $|\lambda| < 1$, then consider the sequence

$$x = (1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots)$$

Claim: $x \in \ell^2$

We have

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} |x_n|^2 = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (|\lambda|^n)^2 = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (|\lambda|^2)^n = \frac{1}{1 - |\lambda|^2} < \infty$$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Now, observe that

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Now, observe that

$$\begin{aligned} T^*x &= T^*(1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots) \\ &= (\lambda, \lambda^2, \lambda^3, \dots) = \lambda(1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots) = \lambda x \end{aligned}$$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

Now, observe that

$$\begin{aligned} T^*x &= T^*(1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots) \\ &= (\lambda, \lambda^2, \lambda^3, \dots) = \lambda(1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots) = \lambda x \end{aligned}$$

So, every $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $|\lambda| < 1$ is an eigenvalue of T^* .

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum
of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of
Spectra of
Operators

The Shift Operator

Now, observe that

$$\begin{aligned} T^*x &= T^*(1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots) \\ &= (\lambda, \lambda^2, \lambda^3, \dots) = \lambda(1, \lambda, \lambda^2, \dots) = \lambda x \end{aligned}$$

So, every $\lambda \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $|\lambda| < 1$ is an eigenvalue of T^* . Now, we have

$$\{\lambda : |\lambda| < 1\} = \{\bar{\lambda} : |\lambda| < 1\} \subseteq \sigma(T)$$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

So,

$$\{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| < 1\} \subseteq \sigma(T) \subseteq \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| \leq 1\}$$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

So,

$$\{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| < 1\} \subseteq \sigma(T) \subseteq \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| \leq 1\}$$

or

$$B(0, 1) \subseteq \sigma(T) \subseteq \overline{B(0, 1)}$$

The Shift Operator

The Spectrum of an Operator

Abdulaziz
AlMutairi

Introduction

Revision

Spectrum

Definition of
Spectrum

Relationship between
Eigenvalue and
Spectrum

Properties and
Theorems

Examples of Spectra of Operators

The Shift Operator

So,

$$\{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| < 1\} \subseteq \sigma(T) \subseteq \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| \leq 1\}$$

or

$$B(0, 1) \subseteq \sigma(T) \subseteq \overline{B(0, 1)}$$

Since $\sigma(T)$ is closed, we have

$$\sigma(T) = \overline{B(0, 1)} = \{\lambda \in \mathbb{C} : |\lambda| \leq 1\}$$